INNOVATION MANAGEMENT

Capsule 1

What is technology?

What is technology? We use this word regularly, but how should we define it? And what does this definition give us?

The word comes from ancient Greek: tékhnê, which refers to manual skill, craft, know-how; and logos, which refers to speech, discourse, knowledge. Technology is therefore the meeting of the two: doing and knowing.

More formally, we can say that technology is a set of means used to achieve a goal. It involves three things: knowledge, particularly scientific knowledge; procedures, that is, ways of doing things; and artefacts, concrete objects.

An important distinction: technology is not technique. Technique is empirical know-how, a knack, like that of a luthier making a violin or of a top athlete. It cannot be codified in a manual. Technology, on the other hand, combines this know-how with knowledge – in particular scientific knowledge – which can be passed on, learned and written down.

And this is where it becomes interesting for management: what matters is not only the object, it is the knowledge behind it. The companies that dominate artificial intelligence today did not develop the best tools by chance; they managed to attract the people who hold the knowledge and know-how needed to implement these tools.

This last point shows the essential role that skills management plays in the management of technology.

English translation of the French script reviewed and approved by the instructor (September 2026). In the video, the image and voice are generated by an AI avatar of the instructor.